A POINT OF ORDER ON THE TWENTY-SEVENTH HOUR

A CORSAIR STORY • FICTION INTERLUDE

Jesse Haddon was fifty-eight years old, which was old enough to know that the universe was enormously large, profoundly strange, and mostly interested in generating paperwork.

As Speaker of the Crossroads Council, Jesse sat behind a heavy cedar table that he had planed and varnished with his own two hands thirty years ago. Outside the high arched windows, the twin world of Nimbus—a swirling sphere of purple and gold sixty thousand miles across—was casually drifting across the afternoon sky toward the sun. In about twenty minutes, it would block the light entirely. The thirty-hour day would pause, the valley would plunge into a sudden, freezing twilight, and the gas lamps out in the square would click on for *The Pause*.

To a poet, it was an awe-inspiring celestial dance. To Jesse, it meant he had exactly twenty minutes to get five very stubborn people to agree on a ditch before the room went dark and his tea went cold.

"It is not merely a question of the ditch," Councilwoman Vaelith was saying, leaning forward until her leafy green hair brushed the ceiling beams. She was an eight-foot-tall Sylvan elder with magnificent wooden tusks, peering down her nose through a pair of tiny brass spectacles. "It is a question of common decency. The new rocket shuttles taking off from the south field are blowing black soot all over the valley. My people hang their bedsheets out to dry in the morning, and by noon they look like chimney sweeps. My cousin's boy had to get married in a grey tunic, Jesse. A *grey* tunic."

On the other side of the table, Brom of the Stone-Carvers Guild gave a long, gravelly sigh that sounded like a wheelbarrow of river rocks being tipped into a creek. Brom was a Craggen, which meant his skin was solid grey granite, his eyes were cut gemstones, and his patience was measured in centuries.

"The shuttles carry iron sewer pipes," Brom rumbled, tapping a thick stone finger on his ledger. "Caldera Foundry makes the pipes on the other side of the mountain. The shuttles bring them here. If we tax the shuttles, the foundry raises the price of the pipes. If the price goes up, we don't finish the sewer. And with all respect to your cousin's wedding, Vaelith, if we don't finish the sewer before the rainy season, clean bedsheets will be the very least of our problems."

"Call the vote, Jesse," hissed Magistrate Ssisera. She was a slender Naga judge, currently coiled in a tight, shivering knot on top of the room's single cast-iron steam radiator, her scaly crest flushed an irritable yellow. "It is the twenty-seventh hour. I am cold, my crest is peeling, and if Nimbus covers the sun before I get a hot bowl of broth, I am going to bite the next person who mentions laundry."

From the open terrace behind the council table, a deep, resonant voice chimed in:

"I rather like the smell of the rockets," the voice rumbled. It was a magnificent sound, like a cathedral pipe organ being played through three feet of warm honey. "It smells like hot iron and ambition. But Vaelith is right about the sheets, Jesse. Grey linens are dreadfully dreary."

Jesse didn't turn around. He didn't need to. Resting his massive chin comfortably on the marble balustrade of the terrace was **Goldheart**.

He was a void dragon. Out in the deep, freezing silence between the stars, he was a creature of myth and terror, a living furnace of bio-fusion capable of outrunning warships and trading blows with alien dreadnoughts. Here in Crossroads Valley, however, where he had lived since the first colony ship opened its hatches five hundred years ago, he was essentially the town's overgrown grandfather. He liked roasted apples, he liked watching the village children play in the square, and above all, he dearly loved municipal meetings. To an immortal being that fed on cosmic energy, there was something endlessly soothing about mortal politics. It was like watching someone fold origami from a legal document so that in the end you could read a haiku from the back of a paper swan. That was the ideal anyway, but the dragon appreciated the effort too.

"Thank you, Goldheart," Jesse said mildly, tapping his wooden gavel. "Your thoughts on bedsheets are, as always, deeply valued. The chair recognizes the dragon's remark. Now, all those in favor of the shuttle drainage fee—"

A horrible, high-pitched whistling shriek tore through the clouds.

It wasn't the polite, muffled hum of a licensed cargo hauler. It was the frantic, screeching howl of a small, stolen hopper engine that was on fire, missing half its thruster nozzles, and falling out of the sky far too fast.

Jesse looked up. Through the hall's stained-glass skylight—an antique window commemorating the First Landing—he saw a streak of greasy black smoke, followed immediately by two pairs of boots. An instant later, the skylight gave way with a sound like a greenhouse being dropped from an orbital crane, showering shards of antique leaded glass and splintered roof tiles across the chamber.

A body struck the center of Jesse's beloved cedar table with the dull, violent impact of a side of beef dropped from a cargo gantry, snapping the center plank clean in half and sending water pitchers, ink pots, and tax ledgers flying in all directions.

Jesse closed his eyes, took a deep breath, and counted slowly to three. When he opened them, a twitchy kid in a grease-stained leather flight jacket was scrambling backward across the ruined table, clutching a humming, glowing hunk of alien metal wrapped in a dirty burlap sack. The object was pulsing with a strange, dull rhythm that made Jesse's front teeth ache. In his other hand, the kid was waving a dented, ugly little machine pistol.

"Stay back!" the kid shrieked, his eyes wild and bloodshot. "Don't touch me! I pulled this core straight out of the old war wreck in the crater! You take one step and I crack the casing! I'll level the whole street!"

Councilwoman Vaelith stared at the wreckage of the table, her wooden spectacles askew on her nose. "Young man," she said in a tone of voice that could freeze boiling water, "you have just ruined a thirty-year-old finish."

"I don't give a damn about your furniture!" the boy screamed, waving the gun at her. "Tell those Corsairs to back off! I'm not going to the penal mines! Tell them to back off!"

Above the hole in the roof, two thick steel cables snapped taut against the iron rafters with the sharp, mechanical bite of industrial winches. Two figures dropped through the opening, hitting the stone floor with the heavy, hydraulic crunch of powered armor. They were covered in soot, their grey metal plates were scraped to bare alloy, and they looked thoroughly, profoundly exhausted.

The lead Corsair brought a heavy, snub-nosed shotgun up to their shoulder in one smooth, practiced motion. Beside them, an elven partner leveled a taser rifle.

"Iron on the floor, kid," the one holding the shotgun rasped through her helmet grille. "Don't do anything stupid. Stupid is what got you into this mess. Put down the gun and live long enough to enjoy some variety in life."

The fugitive backed frantically toward the open terrace, his knuckles white against the grip of his machine pistol. "Stay back! I mean it! One step and I crack the casing! I'll take half the block with me!"

Jesse sighed. He picked up his bent glasses, rubbed the glass dust off them, and set them on his nose.

"Young man," Jesse said politely, "you are already facing three counts of grand larceny, an unlicensed atmospheric descent, and the destruction of a thirty-year-old cedar table. Do not make this afternoon any more expensive than it already is."

The kid's face twisted into desperation. He swiveled the gun straight toward Jesse's chest. "Shut up, old man, or I—"

He didn't finish.

From the sunlit terrace outside, a massive golden foreleg—roughly the thickness of an ancient cedar trunk—reached smoothly through the broken archway. With the gentle, practiced care of someone scooping up a wayward kitten, Goldheart curled his enormous paw around the boy, lifting him six inches clean off the floorboards.

The boy's arms were pinned neatly to his ribs inside a cage of golden, mirror-polished talons. He squirmed. He kicked his heels against empty air. He might as well have been trying to wrestle a mountain range.

Goldheart lowered his enormous horned head into the room. His golden eyes, each the size of a tavern tabletop, blinked down at the suspended thief with mild, grandfatherly reproach. When he exhaled, a warm, fragrant gust of air smelling of cinnamon, summer ozone, and woodsmoke gently ruffled the boy's greasy hair and blew his cap off.

"I wouldn't shoot Jesse if I were you," the dragon rumbled pleasantly, the sound vibrating through the boy's jawbone. "He made that table himself, you know. And when Jesse gets upset, he forgets to put sugar in my tea."

The boy stared into an eye the size of a wagon wheel. His fingers went limp. The machine pistol slipped from his hand and clattered harmlessly against the floorboards. He wondered how a dragon of Goldheart's size could drink a cup of tea.

"Thank you, honoured dragon," the lead Corsair murmured, exhaling in immense relief. Stepping in swiftly, she kicked the pistol into the corner and snapped heavy magnetic cuffs over the kid's wrists as Goldheart gently set him back onto his feet. The elven scout stepped forward with a lead-lined lockbox, popped the humming alien relic inside, and slammed the latches. The thrumming in Jesse's teeth vanished instantly.

The room fell dead silent, save for the tick of the wall clock and the cold wind blowing through the shattered skylight.

Only now, with the fugitive secured, did the two Corsairs seem to fully realize where their chase had ended. They looked around at the vaulted cedar rafters, the stone-faced Craggen, the imposing Sylvan elder, the magistrate shivering on her radiator, and finally up at the colossal golden dragon resting his chin on the balcony.

The lead Corsair hurriedly unlatched her helmet with a sharp hiss of pressurized seals, pulling it off to reveal a soot-streaked face and eyes wide with sudden, flustered mortification. Her posture snapped straight, instantly shifting from hardened void commando to an apologetic schoolchild who had just kicked a ball through the cathedral's finest stained glass.

"Speaker Haddon… Council elders… Honoured Goldheart," she said, her voice dropping into a hasty, respectful bow. "We are… profoundly sorry. For the roof, for the noise, and—most especially—for him. We had him boxed in over the reservoir, but his lateral thruster blew."

Beside her, her partner tilted his head back, stared up through the gaping crater in the ceiling, and muttered under his breath: "Fuck me, is that coming out of our paycheck?"

"Shut up," she hissed out the side of her mouth, bowing even lower toward Jesse. "The Corsair Oversight Committee will cover all structural damages, of course. Full restitution to the municipal treasury within two weeks."

Jesse looked at the broken glass. Then he looked up through the hole in the ceiling.

Outside, the enormous dark curve of Nimbus was sliding cleanly across the face of the sun. The amber sunlight faded into a soft, bruised violet. Down in the square, the gas streetlamps lit with a series of muffled *pops*, their yellow flames flickering in the chilly mountain breeze. *The Pause* had begun.

Jesse picked up the handle of his broken gavel and tapped it against the cedar stump.

"Take him down to the cellar lockup," Jesse said wearily. "Council is adjourned for the eclipse. We'll vote on the sewage pipes once the sun comes back."

Goldheart purred, tucked his great golden snout under his wing on the terrace, and went to sleep in the dark.